

How AI Is Impacting Our Everyday Privacy

Introduction

The use of artificial intelligence, or AI, has become increasingly widespread as the tool continues to develop. More companies are starting or continuing to integrate AI into both development processes and consumer-ready platforms. These companies market these tools as beneficial for all or, at the very least, a neutral addition to their products. However, as these systems become more widely used in everyday scenarios, they also raise significant concerns about privacy, trust, and user autonomy. These concerns are also not immediately visible or widely known to users. Nor do these concerns have clear solutions or remedies that are immediately available for users, either, which leaves a large gap in user protection and accountability.

Two relevant companies that have started putting AI integration at the forefront of their company models are YouTube and Discord. In the past, YouTube has had moderation bots to help creators create content without worry of theft. Most notably, YouTube is best known for its algorithms that aim to help communities seamlessly for users to continue finding what they want. Currently, they are starting to integrate AI into these processes to streamline them and make these features more efficient. However, these features have come with costs and controversies, such as the algorithm sending viewers more videos that contain heavy amounts of misinformation. The other company, Discord, has also recently come into controversy over its use of AI for age verification and automated moderation, labeling it as a necessary safety feature, despite concerns over user privacy. Using external scholarly articles, case studies, concepts from my coursework in information science and statistics, and drawing upon scenarios from personal experience, I aim to address how these concerns come from not only the technical capabilities of AI but also from system design, organizational decision-making, and data management.

Privacy Issues With Artificial Intelligence

The concept of contextual integrity is relevant, as it explains that privacy, especially in the age of technology and AI, is more about the flow of information within an appropriate context (Nissenbaum, 2004). The issues come from when information is being used in contexts that were not outlined or are not being used appropriately. Daniel Solove explains that these privacy concerns are not unique to the introduction of AI. Rather, these concerns have already been brought up since the digital age. However, “AI can increase existing privacy problems, add dimensions, and complexities to them, or remix them (Solove, 2024).” Two of these dimensions consist of scraping and privacy notices. As learned from my coursework, a concept that repeatedly came up when creating a tool or product for users was that you are to clearly outline and state the intent to the users, so that they are able to effectively make decisions within the product (INLS 382, 2025). However, companies, to quickly integrate AI into their products, will quickly create a new privacy policy with shoddy wording and intentionally vague phrasing to hide their intent. This leads users to haphazardly agree to the new policy despite not fully understanding where their data is going. Through this, a loss of control over their own data can occur as the distinction between the collection of data and the generation of data becomes blurred, meaning that the AI may unintentionally circumvent privacy protections and policies (Solove, 2024). A user may not directly state their age, status, interests, or other personal information, yet an AI system may still infer those things based on accumulated or generated data, despite not existing. This makes AI privacy concerns fundamentally different from older concerns centered only on storage and exposure.

Discord Case Study

Recently, there has been a controversy with Discord and its moderation process. In an attempt to increase safety for those who are underage, Discord announced that it would be rolling out a new AI tool to streamline this process. These policies were sent out to users with little time to fully understand the implications, similar to Solove's statement on vague wording for the new terms of service. Discord had started a partnership with the company Persona to handle their age verification process. However, both Discord and Persona received backlash due to the potential of users' data being obtained by AI through other sources, third-party, or publicly available (Roth, 2026). This links back to Solove's argument of loss of control over one's data. In this context, users were worried about their data being taken and used from a context outside that of the age verification. To add on to this, this policy was not written in Discord's privacy policy regarding AI; this was found in their partner's policy, leading to a further loss of control, as Discord's users would not have been aware of their data being used for other means from Discord's policy alone.

This issue can further be understood through a data and information management perspective. From a class regarding the creation and maintenance of databases and database systems, we learn how data is structured, stored, linked, and managed. Information that gets input into a database system can be manipulated and transformed in a way to be able to serve a specific purpose within that organization. (INLS 523, 2025). A platform may collect and store personal information such as photos, IDs, personal history, or bank information. AI systems, such as the ones used by Discord and Persona, may not understand the vague and blurry line of what is needed for proper verification. This data also gets collected by the AI, which may not understand that the data that is collected for verification is not to be used for other means. This creates a distance between the users, the organization, and the AI system. This makes a platform that previously did not have this kind of structure a privacy risk, as users have to give up personal information that is not guaranteed to be used or transformed into other forms.

In a sense, this adds a layer to the implementation of artificial intelligence. The question of implementation is no longer solely up to the effectiveness; in this case, not solely whether it is increasing protection for minors. This new layer adds a cost to said protection. How much are users willing to give up when it comes to privacy and their personal information? While Discord has put a pause on this AI feature and discontinued its partnership with Persona, they showed a willingness to put user privacy below their own priorities, whether it was safety or other goals.

Organizational Responsibility

To build upon the Discord case, another way to approach the issue of privacy is to look not only at the shortcomings of the AI but also at the organization behind the technology. Binns' emphasis that machine learning systems, and in this context, AI, do not simply produce the outcomes but are trained on the specifications given by the organizations that use them (Binns, 2017). This frame of view is important as it shifts responsibility away from the idea that it is up to the algorithm to make all the decisions, and puts responsibility back on the organizations.

In a course that studied how organizations and systems work, we studied that organizations need to develop a proper structure to adopt and implement new systems. This is so that the systems are

implemented in a way that is responsible for all stakeholders involved, including the organization itself, as well as its users (INLS 385, 2024). In cases like YouTube or Discord, companies want to implement AI systems as they make operations more efficient for the company. It's scalable, and due to the recency of AI, it is incredibly marketable as the “new big technology” to stakeholders. However, due to these quick implementations, there may be a lack of long-term implications, especially regarding the ethical use of user data. This benefit and cost line is purely an organizational decision. From an organizational perspective, this means that controversy or unfavorable results are not solely a matter of technological issues, but a reflection of where the priorities of the organization lie, where a lack of privacy is an unavoidable byproduct of efficiency from the services provided. This prioritization of efficiency over stakeholders reflects an issue within the organization, in which they are oftentimes prioritizing the idea of implementation of AI, short-term efficiency, and short-term profits, whereas the long-term effects are significantly underrepresented (INLS 385, 2024).

YouTube Case Study

Looking at specific instances of YouTube's recommendation algorithm serves as a good case study for how privacy can become a concern and a highlight of the organization's priorities when implementing AI into its systems. Recommendation systems are framed as both a convenience feature and a personalization tool for the user. It creates its algorithm by tracking the users' habits, such as which videos they have watched, the types of videos they are clicking on, watch time, and metrics such as liking, disliking, or sharing the video (Goodrow, 2021). A study done on YouTube's recommendation system further goes deeper into this by explaining that the system uses “deep learning as a general-purpose solution for nearly all learning problems (Covington et al., 2016).” This means that for the recommendation algorithm, the system continuously learns from users' actions to make their recommendations and predictions better.

The privacy concern that arises from this is that these habits that the algorithm collects can create a profile about the user, despite the user not necessarily disclosing certain information. This profile allows YouTube to optimize the site for the user, but it also allows YouTube to transform and direct how users interact with their site, just from the data collected. The algorithm itself prioritizes the engagement of users by trying to keep them on the website for as long as possible. This means, from the profile that YouTube creates about a user, the algorithm is trying to increase the user's time by recommending videos that would keep the user continuously engaged in a way where the user is not stopping at one or two videos. As mentioned while discussing organizational responsibility, this shows that there is a difference in priority between the user and the organization. For the user, the algorithm is a way to efficiently get more content that the user would like to watch. For the company, this is a way to gain more retention on its website by continuously building a profile for the user based on information both disclosed and implicit. The current AI system, while not inherently negative, holds privacy concerns due to the user profiles that get built, oftentimes without users' knowledge. While YouTube does have options for users to toggle the type of information that gets collected, oftentimes this information is not explicit and comes from more unseen factors. This has implications in various spheres, such as personalized advertising and misinformation bubbles through constant recommendations.

Conclusion

In both the cases of Discord and YouTube, despite having AI for different purposes, they show a wider concern over privacy when it comes to artificial intelligence taking our personal data. Discord shows a more apparent privacy concern as personal data was being requested where it previously had not been. This privacy concern came not only from the relinquishing of private data, but also from how the data would be used or could be used without the user's knowledge. This case demonstrated the concept of loss of data control and the difference between how organizations should approach change in service and how organizations actually approach it. In the case of Discord, the AI systems were seemingly implemented and developed hastily without proper oversight when it came to making the policies, while focused on more short-term benefits. In this vein, the issue and concern over privacy was not only the usage of artificial intelligence, but also how the organizations used the system and the collected data.

YouTube shows this way that privacy concerns could be looked through a lens of organizational priorities and how they contrast with user interests. In this case study, the concern over privacy as opposed to Discord is a lot more subtle, as users are not necessarily aware of the extent to which they are being surveyed for the AI system. It shows a contrast that the profile being created by users is perceived as a dataset for efficiency and convenience, whereas the organizational priority is to have the system increase user retention, with the implications that user data could be used for other things within the algorithm.

Despite the differences in implementation, both cases demonstrate areas in which AI is being implemented into platforms that people may use every day, and how the way they are implemented is a cause for concern regarding the privacy of the users. In conclusion, the usage of AI in platforms does not inherently mean that there are privacy issues from the get-go. From an information science point of view, privacy concerns from AI being implemented come not only from the effectiveness but also from the connections between the system design, the organizational priorities, and the data transformation, both intentional and unintentional. These interconnected concepts lead to ideas of high efficiency and short-term profit while undermining the concerns of stakeholders, which can be exemplified through the case studies outlined in this paper.

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